
Paper 2, Option 2B.1: Luther and the German Reformation, c1515–55

Overview

This option comprises a study in depth of Luther's challenge to the Catholic Church, the development of a separate Lutheran Church within the German states, and the response of Empire and the papacy to this challenge to 1555. This would cause a fracture in the religious unity of western Christianity, which would, in time, spread through Europe and beyond.

Students will gain an in-depth understanding of Luther's religious protests and the involvement of secular and religious leaders in driving, and resisting, religious and political change in the German states in this period.

Key topics	Content
1 Conditions in early sixteenth-century Germany	• The Holy Roman Empire: the structure of central government; the seven electors; the respective powers of the Emperor and the princes; the imperial election of 1519. • The state of the German economy: growing towns and cities; trade and communications between the states. • The German Catholic Church: the religious and secular power of the bishops; the parish clergy; anticlericalism and popular piety; the influence of humanism. • The papacy and Germany: the corruption of the papal court; papal financial demands on Germany; Tetzels and the sale of indulgences.
2 Luther's early challenge to the Catholic Church, 1517–20	• The influences on Luther's views; his views on corruption within the Catholic Church. • <i>The Ninety-Five Theses</i> 1517: Luther's rejection of indulgences; his aim of promoting academic debate; the publication of the <i>Ninety-Five Theses</i> and their impact; the importance of the printing press. • The shaping of Luther's beliefs: his protest to Albert of Mainz; the response of Leo X to Luther's early challenge; the debate with Cajetan in 1518; significance of the debate with Eck in 1519. • Luther's excommunication 1520: Luther's tower experience and his acceptance of justification by faith alone; the 1520 pamphlets addressed to the clergy, nobility and the German people; the burning of the Bull of Excommunication in 1520.

Key topics	Content
3 The development of Lutheranism, 1521–46	• The Diet of Worms and its aftermath: Luther's condemnation as a heretic and an outlaw; the attitude of Charles V; the protection of Frederick the Wise at Wartburg Castle. • Luther's attitude to religious and political radicalism: views on the Radical Reformation by Carlstadt and the Zwickau prophets in Wittenberg, his lack of support for the revolt of the Imperial Knights; the reasons for, and consequences of, his denunciation of the Peasants' War 1525; the effect of Luther's political conservatism on the German princes. • Lutheran beliefs and their influence: the importance of justification; the German Mass; the doctrine of the Real Presence; Luther's translation of the Bible; the <i>Large Catechism</i> and <i>Small Catechism</i>; the growing popularity of Lutheranism within Germany. • Luther's declining influence, 1530–46: Philip Melanchthon's codification of Lutheran beliefs; the Loci Communes 1521; the Augsburg Confession 1530 and its importance; growing divergence between Catholic and Lutheran beliefs; Luther and the Philip of Hesse affair 1540.
4 The spread and survival of Lutheranism, 1521–55	• The failure of Lutheran-Catholic negotiations: the Diets of Speyer 1526 and 1529; the Diet of Regensburg 1541. • The role of the German princes: Luther's protection by Frederick the Wise; the significance of the conversion of Albrecht of Hohenzollern, Philip of Hesse and John of Saxony; formation of the Schmalkaldic League 1531; the League's significance for the spread of Lutheranism. • Charles V and Lutheranism: his conflicting priorities in Spain, France and against the Ottomans; limited support for Charles from the Catholic princes; the significance of the Schmalkaldic War; the Peace of Passau 1552; the Peace of Augsburg 1555. • The papacy and Lutheranism: the failure to respond effectively to Luther; Paul III and attempts at reform; the Consilium 1537; the summoning of the Council of Trent.